

Thoughts: Graduating With a 4.0

“Bruh Kyle of course you got summa cum laude. You love school.” I bumped into a high school friend one night towards the end of spring quarter. We’re close enough to make small talk whenever we bump into each other, but we’ve never scheduled something together throughout all our time in college. I thought it was funny he knew I was graduating with summa cum laude, since you have to manually look through the engineering graduation pamphlet preview to find out anything related to this type of stuff. And actually, I think loving school has little to do with it even if that sounds like a lie.

I do love school, but that’s because I love learning and I love being around people. What drove me throughout college to do well (and what drives me generally in life) is an attitude that I should always bring my best to whatever it is I’m doing. That’s why I poured hours into homework, studied well before exams, practiced serves at the tennis courts at a time I couldn’t even hit solid groundstrokes, and brought my best to lab even when I felt like I didn’t know anything related to the research.

Early on in college, academic success was all that mattered. Classes were all online, no one could go out to see friends, club meetings were boring, Zoom socials were awkward, and there really didn’t feel like much to life besides school. This type of lifestyle carried over into my 2nd year, a time when much was still shut down and people were still careful about anything in person. But the following summer in NYC changed my perspective on life – I wanted to go out more, eat different food, spend more time with friends, make new friends, and find how much life there was to live aside from studying. And that I did!

Junior year was a time I started finding out how I wanted to live my future life. I still very much cared about school and my career, but I realized what type of balance between making a living and making life fulfilling it is I wanted. I started going to the gym with friends more, playing more tennis, and taking spontaneous adventures around the area (Westwood, Santa Monica, Sawtelle) whenever I could.

This energy was amplified during my 4th year. Fall quarter was my first quarter living in apartments. And what better location than the boundary of campus and Westwood? Living at Gayley Heights enabled such a different lifestyle. We went all out in fall quarter, driving hours on day trips to surrounding neighborhoods, beaches, Universal, Disney, and even a far away neighborhood on the water famous for their Christmas displays. We went out to eat or stayed in and cooked together. We saw more of KTown, so much so that at some point we were going 3 times a week even though the bus ride there and back is almost an hour each! My classes weren't necessarily easier, but I planned my time much better. I wrote down everything I ever did or planned on my calendar and made sure I had time to do what I wanted both in and out of school. Without my calendar, I wouldn't have been able to achieve the balance I needed to live an exciting life while learning what I needed to learn.

Winter quarter was even more insane. I joined club tennis, made close friends, and went out so much that people commented it seemed like I wasn't even taking classes – that I was on vacation! All of this was unsustainable for my wallet, so I picked up a couple side jobs to support all the fun. With only 1 CS class, I was blessed with an especially light schedule in winter quarter. I guess it's sort of dumb luck that my class schedule panned out the way it did, since I didn't feel I had to work very hard winter quarter to maintain my grades. I don't consider myself very smart, and I always felt I had to put in a lot of work to perform the way I wanted to perform. But I do think I'm exceptionally driven and focused, which is why I did well in school even in quarters prior to winter of 4th year.

Spring quarter came along, and I thought I'd have it easy with only 2 CS classes, one of which was a research communications class that was almost no work compared to most classes. Unfortunately for me, the other class was the CS capstone, which involves a quarter-long project where you and a team of 4 have to develop a web server with robust testing, monitoring, etc. almost completely from scratch (for non-CS readers, this is a project magnitudes more involved than most anything we've dealt with in undergrad). I felt continually burdened by this class since I like frontloading the hard work much before deadlines, but my teammates often did work the night or two before things were due.

Our assignment grades were often short of the median, which made me stressed in a way I hadn't felt since sophomore year, when almost my entire life was school. I hadn't previously cared much for maintaining a 4.0, but realizing I was only 1 quarter away from graduating with a perfect record made me want it more than I'd expected. Throughout the quarter, I lost sleep working crazy hours to troubleshoot problems with teammates, but I felt it was worth it to get an A.

Tennis became something I looked forward to not only because of how crazy fun it is hitting and talking with friends on the court and in the stadium, but because it was some of the only time my mind was completely clear of the capstone work. Looking back on my calendar, I still went out literally almost every night I didn't have tennis, but many of those nights I was a bit distracted thinking of the project and planning things out.

Now that I'm on the other side of the class, I do regret some of the stress. My GPA genuinely does not affect my life in any concrete way (besides to make my parents smile, which is very important!). And I do wish my last quarter was completely carefree. But spring still ended up being a time I truly did enjoy the company of friends, old and new (surprisingly, I think this last spring quarter might've been the one quarter I made the most new friends). Even though I was thinking of that dumb project all the time, it's not the care for the class that I regret, but the stress I put on myself that I regret.

My greatest takeaway from looking back on this part of college is knowing I'll learn what I need to learn in order to succeed in my future career. I think most of the graduates from UCLA Engineering can agree. Classes have given us a great foundation and broad understanding of many topics throughout our fields. And I've proven to myself that I can do well when I put in the hard work. But what is it I'll remember most about college? None of the studying, not a single question from the problem sets, and not the projects we've built. What I'll remember most about college is all the memories with friends we've made. The laughs, the cries, the stupid stuff, the fun stuff, and everything in between. It's the long drives with friends. The parties full

of people that were once strangers but now familiar faces. The end of quarter hangouts with besties and the end of quarter hangouts with people I wish I'd met sooner.

What sucks most about college is graduating and seeing how geographically fragmented¹ we all are. It especially hurts to feel like I'm getting to know certain people and suddenly have them ripped away. And it hurts to not live 5 minutes away from or even in the same room as my best friends. I know this type of pain is greater than any pain I would've ever felt from not getting an A.

I guess what I want to say is that it's not grades that matter – it's the learning that matters. Learning and doing your best in school while doing your best to maintain and form new relationships. GPA is only one measure of success, but I think a much more valuable one coming fresh out of college is how much your friends collectively represent the type of person you want to be. I've always believed in the saying that you can tell what type of person someone is based on the people they choose to surround themselves with. Finding my community will forever be the most valuable part of these last 4 years to me. I'm grateful beyond words to have met the people that I now consider my closest friends.

¹ Thanks Celebi for that phrase